

Word family: **listen / listens / listened / listening / listener**

Base word: listen

Past tense: listened

Past participle: listened

Related forms: listening, listener

Useful expressions / extensions: listen to, listen for, listen closely, listen in, active listening, good listener

Part of speech: mainly verb (動詞) / noun-related forms (相關名詞)

Your sentence:

> “She is not the sort of person who tries to dominate a conversation, but when she does speak, people **listen**.”

Meaning in this passage

Here, **listen** means **to pay attention to what someone is saying because their words are considered worth hearing**.

The sentence does not merely mean that people physically hear her voice. It suggests that when your grandmother speaks, others **stop, pay attention, and take her words seriously**.

繁體中文: **專心聽某人說話，留意並重視對方所說的內容；在這裡帶有「大家願意聽她的話、重視她的意見」的意味**

中文翻譯:

> “When she does speak, people listen.”

「但每當她開口，大家都會**認真聽她說話 / 願意聽她的意見**。」

Here:

people listen = 大家會停下來專心聽，而且重視她所說的內容

1. **listen = pay attention to sound/speech (專心聽) — 聽 ; 聆聽**

This is the exact core sense in your passage.

Practice 1 — Original

> “When she does speak, people **listen**.”

「每當她開口，大家都會**認真聽**。」

Practice 2

> “Please **listen** carefully.”

「請**仔細聽**。」

Practice 3

> “The children sat quietly and **listened**.”

「孩子們安靜地坐著**聆聽**。」

****listen = 主動把注意力放在聲音或說話內容上****

2. ****listen to + person (聽某人說話) — 聽；聆聽****

A crucial grammatical pattern.

Practice 4

> “She always **listens to** me when I have a problem.”

「我有問題時，她總是會**聽我說**。」

Practice 5

> “You should **listen to** your grandmother.”

「你應該**聽外婆說話**。」

****listen to someone = 把注意力放在某人的說話內容上****

Important grammar:

> ****listen to someone**** 

> ****listen someone**** 

3. ****listen to + sound/music (聽聲音 / 音樂) — 聽****

Practice 6

> “She likes to **listen to** classical music.”

「她喜歡**聽古典音樂**。」

Practice 7

> “We sat outside and **listened to** the rain.”

「我們坐在外面**聽雨聲**。」

listen to something = 主動把注意力放在某種聲音、音樂或錄音上

4. **listen** = take someone's words seriously (聽取 / 重視意見) — 聽從 ; 重視

This is an important figurative/pragmatic extension and very relevant to your passage.

Practice 8

> “People **listen** when she gives advice.”

「她給建議時，人們都會**認真聽取**。」

Practice 9

> “Managers need to **listen** to their staff.”

「經理需要**聽取員工的意見**。」

listen = 不只是聽到聲音，而是認真考慮和重視對方所說的內容

This is especially close to your original sentence.

5. **listen to advice/warnings** (聽取建議 / 警告) — 聽從 ; 接受

Practice 10

> “You should **listen to** her advice.”

「你應該**聽取 / 聽從她的建議**。」

Practice 11

> “He refused to **listen to** the warning.”

「他拒絕**聽取那個警告**。」

listen to advice/warnings = 願意接受並認真考慮別人的建議或警告

Depending on context, this can imply actual obedience.

6. **listen = obey / do what someone says (聽話) — 聽從 ; 照做**

A stronger branch.

Practice 12

> “You never **listen**!”

「你從來都**不聽話 / 不聽人勸**！」

Practice 13

> “The child finally **listened** and put the toy away.”

「那個孩子最後終於**聽話**，把玩具收起來。」

listen = 接受別人的指示、要求或勸告，並照著做

This is stronger than merely paying attention.

7. **listen for + sound (留心聽某個聲音) — 留意 ; 留心聽**

A useful grammatical contrast.

Practice 14

> “**Listen for** the doorbell.”

「**留心聽**門鈴聲。」

Practice 15

> “She **listened for** her name.”

「她**留心聽著**有沒有人叫自己的名字。」

listen for something = 集中注意力，等待某個特定聲音出現

Compare:

> **listen to music** = 聽正在出現的音樂

> **listen for the bell** = 等著聽某個聲音是否出現

8. **listen closely/carefully (仔細聽) — 專心聽；仔細聆聽**

Practice 16

> “**Listen closely** to what she says.”

「**仔細聽**她說甚麼。」

Practice 17

> “He **listened carefully** to the instructions.”

「他**仔細聽取**指示。」

listen closely/carefully = 高度集中注意力去理解聲音或說話內容

9. **listen in = listen to a conversation/broadcast (收聽 / 偷聽) — 收聽；旁聽；偷聽**

A common phrasal extension with multiple contexts.

Practice 18

> “Thousands of people **listened in** to the interview.”

「數以千計的人**收聽了**這次訪問。」

Practice 19

> “I wasn’t trying to **listen in** on your conversation.”

「我不是故意要**偷聽你們的談話**。」

****listen in = 收聽某個廣播 / 談話，或在沒有直接參與的情況下聽別人的對話****

Context determines whether it is neutral or intrusive.

10. ****listener = person who listens (聽者) — 聽眾；聆聽者****

The main person noun.

Practice 20

> “She is a very good ****listener****.”

「她是一個很好的****聆聽者 / 很會聽別人說話的人****。」

Practice 21

> “Radio ****listeners**** called in with questions.”

「電台****聽眾****打電話進來提問。」

****listener = 聽某人說話、音樂、廣播等的人****

The natural Chinese depends on context:

* conversation → 聆聽者

* radio → 聽眾

* podcast → 聽眾

11. ****good listener — 善於聆聽的人****

Very relevant to your grandmother passage.

Practice 22

> “She is a ****good listener**** and rarely interrupts.”

「她很****懂得聆聽別人****，很少打斷別人。」

Practice 23

> “A good ****listener**** makes people feel understood.”

「一個懂得**聆聽**的人會令人感到被理解。」

good listener = 願意專心聽、理解別人，而且不急於打斷或把話題轉回自己身上的人

12. **listening = act/skill of paying attention (聆聽) — 聆聽；聽力**

Practice 24

> “Good **listening** is an important communication skill.”

「良好的**聆聽能力**是一項重要溝通技巧。」

Practice 25

> “The course includes speaking and **listening** practice.”

「這個課程包括口語和**聽力**練習。」

listening = 主動接收並理解聲音 / 說話內容的行為或能力

13. **listening = language skill (語言學習) — 聽力**

Practice 26

> “My English **listening** has improved.”

「我的英語**聽力**進步了。」

Practice 27

> “The exam tests reading and **listening**.”

「考試測試閱讀和**聽力**能力。」

listening = 理解口語語言的能力，尤其在語言學習 / 測驗中

14. **active listening — 積極聆聽**

A very useful communication term.

Practice 28

> “**Active listening** helps people feel respected.”

「**積極聆聽**有助令人感到受到尊重。」

Practice 29

> “The training teaches **active listening** skills.”

「這項培訓教授**積極聆聽技巧**。」

****active listening = 專心聆聽、確認理解、適當回應並讓對方感到自己真正被聽見的溝通方式****

This is especially relevant to your grandmother's later behaviour:

> “she listens first and then gives simple but thoughtful advice.”

15. ****listening comprehension — 聽力理解****

Practice 30

> “The exercise tests **listening comprehension**.”

「這項練習測試**聽力理解能力**。」

Practice 31

> “Watching interviews can improve **listening comprehension**.”

「觀看訪問可以提升**聽力理解能力**。」

****listening comprehension = 聽到口語後準確理解其內容、意思和細節的能力****

16. ****listening device (設備) — 監聽 / 收音設備****

A useful technology/security compound.

Practice 32

> “The microphone can be used as a **listening device**.”

「這個咪高峰可以用作**收音 / 監聽設備**。」

Practice 33

> “Investigators found a hidden **listening device**.”

「調查人員發現了一個隱藏的**監聽裝置**。」

****listening device = 用來收取、記錄或監聽聲音 / 談話的裝置****

The security/surveillance context makes the Chinese more specific.

17. ****listening audience (媒體) — 收聽群眾 ; 聽眾****

Practice 34

> “The programme has a large **listening audience**.”

「這個節目有龐大的**聽眾群**。」

Practice 35

> “The station is trying to attract a younger **listening audience**.”

「電台正嘗試吸引較年輕的**聽眾群體**。」

****listening audience = 透過廣播、音訊或其他聲音媒體收聽內容的一群人****

Important distinction: **listen vs hear**

This is the most important contrast.

****hear****

= sound reaches your ears, often automatically.

> “I heard a noise.”

「我聽到一個聲音。」

****listen****

= deliberately pay attention to sound.

> “I listened to the noise.”

「我專心聽那個聲音。」

So:

****hear = 聽到****

****listen = 聆聽 / 專心去聽****

Your sentence says:

> “people listen”

not merely:

> “people hear her.”

That shows ****attention and respect****.

Important distinction: **listen vs listen to**

**listen**

can appear without an object:

> “Listen!”

「聽著！」

**listen to + object**

when naming the person/sound:

> “Listen to her.”

「聽她說。」

Therefore:

> ****listen her**** ❌

> ****listen to her**** ✅

This is one of the most important grammar points.

Important distinction: **listen to vs listen for**

listen to

= pay attention to something already audible/present.

> “Listen to the music.”

listen for

= wait attentively for a specific sound.

> “Listen for your name.”

So:

listen to = 聽某個正在出現的聲音

listen for = 留心等某個聲音出現

Important distinction: **listen to someone vs obey someone**

These overlap only sometimes.

listen to someone

can simply mean:

> pay attention to what they say.

obey someone

means:

> do what they instruct/order.

A person can listen carefully but still disagree.

However, in:

> “You never listen to me!”

****listen**** can imply:

> you never take my advice / do what I tell you.

Context matters.

Important distinction: **listen vs understand**

**listen**

= attend to the spoken message.

**understand**

= comprehend its meaning.

You can:

> listen without understanding

especially in a language you do not know.

So good communication requires both.

Important distinction: **listen vs pay attention**

**pay attention**

is broader.

You can pay attention to:

* a speaker

* a screen

* traffic

* written instructions

**listen**

specifically involves sound/speech.

So:

> listening is one form of paying attention.

Important distinction: ****listener vs audience****

****listener****

= an individual person who listens.

****audience****

= a group receiving a performance, speech, programme, etc.

A radio audience consists of many listeners.

Important distinction: ****listener vs hearer****

****listener****

implies active attention.

****hearer****

simply means someone who hears, and is much less common in ordinary conversation.

For learner use, ****listener**** is much more important.

Important distinction: ****good listener vs quiet person****

A quiet person is not automatically a good listener.

****quiet person****

= speaks little.

****good listener****

= actively pays attention, understands, responds, and gives others room to speak.

Your grandmother is portrayed as both, but these are separate qualities.

Important distinction: ****listening vs hearing****

****hearing****

can mean:

- * the ability/sense of hearing
- * the act of perceiving sound
- * a formal legal meeting

****listening****

specifically means:

> actively paying attention to sound or speech.

For language learning:

> ****listening practice****

not normally:

> hearing practice.

Important distinction: ****active listening vs passive listening****

****active listening****

includes:

- * concentration
- * feedback
- * clarification
- * showing understanding

****passive listening****

means hearing/listening without much active response or engagement.

This distinction is useful in communication training.

Family-extension note

Following the same curation style, these are especially useful members and constructions of the **listen** family:

- * **listen — pay attention to sound** = 專心聽 / 聆聽
- * **listen to someone** = 聽某人說話
- * **listen to music/sound** = 聽音樂 / 聲音
- * **listen — take seriously** = 認真聽取 / 重視
- * **listen to advice/warnings** = 聽取 / 聽從建議或警告
- * **listen — obey** = 聽話 / 照做
- * **listen for** = 留心等待某個聲音
- * **listen closely/carefully** = 仔細聆聽
- * **listen in** = 收聽 / 旁聽 / 偷聽
- * **listener** = 聽眾 / 聆聽者
- * **good listener** = 善於聆聽的人
- * **listening — general** = 聆聽行為 / 能力
- * **listening — language skill** = 聽力
- * **active listening** = 積極聆聽
- * **listening comprehension** = 聽力理解
- * **listening device** = 收音 / 監聽裝置

As in the reference examples, this family is more **construction-rich** than **derivationally rich**. The main learning value comes from distinguishing **active attention**, **taking advice seriously**, and patterns such as **listen to** versus **listen for**, rather than manufacturing many unrelated senses.

Master comparison

Form / sense	MCQ-ready Traditional Chinese meaning
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listen — pay attention	主動把注意力放在聲音或說話內容上
listen to someone	專心留意某人的說話內容
listen to sound/music	主動把注意力放在某種聲音、音樂或錄音上
listen — take seriously	不只是聽到，而是認真重視和考慮對方所說的內容
listen to advice/warnings	願意接受並認真考慮別人的建議或警告
listen — obey	接受別人的指示 / 勸告並照著做
listen for	集中注意力等待某個特定聲音出現
listen closely/carefully	高度集中注意力以理解聲音或說話內容

listen in — broadcast	收聽某個廣播、談話或節目	
listen in — conversation	在沒有直接參與的情況下旁聽 / 偷聽別人的談話	
listener	正在聽某人、音樂、廣播等內容的人	
good listener	願意專心聽、理解並給別人充分表達空間的人	
listening — general	主動接收並理解聲音或說話的行為 / 能力	
listening — language skill	理解口語語言的聽力能力	
active listening	專心聆聽、確認理解並適當回應的溝通方式	
listening comprehension	聽到口語後理解其意思、內容和細節的能力	
listening device	用來收取、記錄或監聽聲音 / 談話的裝置	

For your original sentence

> “She is not the sort of person who tries to dominate a conversation, but when she does speak, people **listen**.”

The exact meaning is:

listen = 專心聽她說話，而且重視她所說的內容

Therefore:

> **people listen**

= **「大家會停下來認真聽，而且把她的話放在心上」**

This is stronger than simply:

> **people hear her**

> = 大家聽到她的聲音

The sentence suggests **attention + respect**.

And the contrast is beautifully deliberate:

> she does not dominate the conversation

> but when she speaks, people listen.

Her influence comes not from speaking frequently, but from **the weight people give to her words**.